IB DIPLOMA PROGRAMME

Global Politics
Complete Cheat Sheet

Full Syllabus · HL + SL · Score a 7

🌐 Power & Sovereignty ⚖️ Human Rights 📊 Development 🕊️ Peace & Conflict

📚	🎯	🌍
20 Pages	**Exam-Focused**	**Case Studies**
Full syllabus coverage	Tips, mistakes & strategy	Real-world examples throughout

WHAT'S INSIDE

🔵 **Section 1:** Power, Sovereignty & IR — pages 3–6

🔴 **Section 2:** Human Rights — pages 7–9

🟡 **Section 3:** Development — pages 10–12

🟢 **Section 4:** Peace & Conflict — pages 13–15

🏆 **Section 5:** HL Extensions — pages 16–17

📝 **Section 6:** Exam Mastery — pages 18–20

💡 **EXAM TIP —** Use this cheat sheet for final revision. Each page covers one topic area — scan cards & boxes first, then read bullet points. Complete the "night before" checklist on page 20.

HOW TO USE THIS SHEET

1. **Scan:** Read section headers and card titles first — get the big picture.
2. **Focus:** Deep-dive into Exam Tip and Evaluation boxes for mark-scoring content.
3. **Case Studies:** Memorise at least 2 per topic — use them in Paper 2 essays.
4. **Mistakes:** Read warning boxes — these cost marks in exams.
5. **Night Before:** Use page 20 checklist to verify all concepts are solid.

Legend

- **Exam Tip** — what examiners look for
- ⚠ **Common Mistake** — avoid these errors
- ⚖ **Evaluation** — multiple perspectives
- HL — Higher Level extension only
- CASE STUDY — real-world example

FULL SYLLABUS MAP

1 Power, Sovereignty & IR

- Hard vs soft power
- Sovereignty & legitimacy
- State & non-state actors
- IR theories (Realism, Liberalism, Constructivism)
- Global governance & the UN

2 Human Rights

- Generations of rights
- Universal vs cultural relativism
- Human rights violations
- Enforcement mechanisms
- R2P & humanitarian intervention

3 Development

- Development indicators (HDI, GDP)
- Modernisation vs dependency theory
- Aid, trade & debt
- SDGs & sustainable development
- Role of IGOs & NGOs

4 Peace & Conflict

- Types of conflict (interstate, civil)
- Causes of conflict
- Negative & positive peace (Galtung)
- Peacebuilding & peacekeeping
- Role of international actors

EXAM TIP — You will study ONE of the four topics as your **core** and explore **two additional topics**. For HL, a political engagement activity (PEA) and a global political challenge (GPC) are also assessed. All four topics appear in Paper 1 (structured questions) and Paper 2 (extended essays).

IB ASSESSMENT OVERVIEW

Component	SL	HL	What to Study
Paper 1 — structured questions	35%	20%	Two topics — define concepts, analyse, evaluate
Paper 2 — essay	35%	25%	Two topics — 1,000-word extended argument
Internal Assessment (IA)	30%	20%	Political engagement activity + reflective journal
HL Extension — GPC essay	—	35%	Global Political Challenge — 2,000-word essay

🔵 POWER

Hard Power

- Coercive force — military & economic pressure
- Used to compel or deter other actors
- **Examples:** sanctions (US vs Iran), military invasion, trade embargoes
- **Theorist:** Realism (Morgenthau, Mearsheimer)

Soft Power

- Attraction through culture, values, diplomacy
- Shapes preferences rather than dictating behaviour
- **Examples:** US Hollywood, Korean Wave (K-pop), BBC
- **Theorist:** Joseph Nye (coined the term, 1990)

Smart Power

- Strategic combination of hard + soft power
- Obama's foreign policy doctrine
- Also see: **sharp power** — manipulation/disinformation (Russia, China)

⚖ **EVALUATION —** Hard power is more immediately effective but damages legitimacy; soft power is sustainable but slow. Smart power is theoretically ideal but difficult to implement consistently.

🏛 SOVEREIGNTY

Westphalian Sovereignty (1648)

- Territorial integrity & non-interference
- State = supreme authority within borders
- Foundation of international law (UN Charter Art. 2.1)

Challenges to Sovereignty

- **Globalisation:** TNCs, financial flows override state control
- **R2P:** humanitarian intervention (Kosovo 1999, Libya 2011)
- **Supranational bodies:** EU — members cede sovereignty
- **Non-state actors:** ISIS, Al-Qaeda — challenge territorial control

⚡ LEGITIMACY

Type	Source	Example
Democratic	Elections, consent	Western states
Traditional	Heredity, custom	Saudi Arabia, UK monarchy
Charismatic	Personal authority	Mandela, Hitler
Legal-rational	Rule of law, constitution	Most modern states

💡 **EXAM TIP —** IB loves "legitimacy" — always ask: *who grants legitimacy?* and *what happens when it is lost?* (e.g. Arab Spring = collapse of authoritarian legitimacy).

⚠ **COMMON MISTAKE —** "Sovereignty" and "power" are not the same thing. Sovereignty is a legal concept (right to rule); power is a capability (ability to act). A weak state can be sovereign but have little power (e.g. Somalia).

💰 Economic Power

- GDP, trade capacity, investment flows
- Financial leverage: World Bank, IMF conditions
- Sanctions as economic coercion
- **Examples:** China's Belt & Road Initiative (BRI), US dollar dominance (petrodollar)

⚔️ Military Power

- Armed forces, nuclear deterrence, alliances
- NATO — collective security & power projection
- Proxy wars: Cold War, Syria
- **Examples:** US global military bases, Russian nuclear arsenal

🎭 Cultural Power

- Language, media, arts, education
- Cultural imperialism debate
- **Americanisation** vs **hybridity**
- **Examples:** Confucius Institutes (China), French Francophonie

STATE VS NON-STATE ACTORS

Actor Type	Key Features	Examples	Role in Global Politics
State Actors	Sovereign territory, government, population, legal recognition	USA, China, Nigeria, Brazil	Primary actors; hold veto in UNSC (P5); set international law
IGOs	Membership of states; created by treaty	UN, NATO, WTO, IMF, WHO	Multilateral cooperation; binding resolutions (UNSC)
NGOs	Civil society; non-profit; independent of states	Amnesty International, MSF, Greenpeace	Advocacy, service delivery, norm promotion
TNCs	For-profit; operate across borders; GDP may exceed states	Amazon, Shell, Google, Apple	Economic power; lobbying; tax avoidance; job creation/exploitation
Armed Non-State Actors	Use violence; not recognised internationally	ISIS, Hezbollah, Taliban, FARC	Destabilise states; challenge sovereignty; terrorism
Intergovernmental Networks	Informal groupings of states	G7, G20, BRICS, ASEAN	Economic coordination; emerging power blocs

⚖ **EVALUATION — Are states still the dominant actors?** Realists: YES — states remain primary. Liberals: increasingly NO — IGOs and NGOs shape outcomes. Constructivists: depends on norms and identity. TNCs: economically, some exceed state power (Apple GDP > Saudi Arabia).

💡 **EXAM TIP —** When asked about "global actors," always mention **at least two types** (e.g. a state AND an IGO AND an NGO) and explain **how they interact**. Examiners want to see awareness of complexity.

⚔ REALISM

Core Assumptions

- States are unitary, rational actors
- Anarchic international system
- States primarily pursue **national security**
- Power is zero-sum

Key Thinkers

- Thucydides, Machiavelli
- Hans Morgenthau — *Politics Among Nations*
- Kenneth Waltz (structural/neorealism)
- Mearsheimer (offensive realism)

Concepts

- Balance of power
- Security dilemma
- Self-help system

Case Study

- Cold War arms race
- Russia–Ukraine War 2022
- China's South China Sea expansion

🤝 LIBERALISM

Core Assumptions

- States can cooperate for mutual benefit
- International institutions matter
- Democracy promotes peace
- Economic interdependence reduces conflict

Key Thinkers

- Immanuel Kant — *Perpetual Peace*
- Woodrow Wilson (14 Points, League of Nations)
- Robert Keohane & Joseph Nye

Concepts

- Democratic peace theory
- Complex interdependence
- Multilateralism & regimes

Case Study

- EU integration
- WTO trade rules
- Paris Climate Agreement

🧠 CONSTRUCTIVISM

Core Assumptions

- International reality is **socially constructed**
- Ideas, norms, identity shape behaviour
- State interests are not fixed
- Anarchy is "what states make of it"

Key Thinkers

- Alexander Wendt — *Social Theory of IR*
- John Ruggie — multilateralism as norm
- Martha Finnemore — norm diffusion

Concepts

- Norm cascades
- Identity & interests
- Socialisation of states

Case Study

- Human rights norm expansion (post-WWII)
- Anti-apartheid movement
- R2P emergence at UN

QUICK COMPARISON TABLE

Dimension	Realism	Liberalism	Constructivism
Main focus	Power & security	Cooperation & institutions	Norms, identity, ideas
View of states	Self-interested, rational	Capable of cooperation	Socially constructed
International order	Anarchic & competitive	Can be governed by rules	Depends on shared norms
War	Inevitable, rational	Reduced by democracy & trade	Depends on identities & norms
Key weakness	Ignores non-material factors	Overly optimistic	Hard to test empirically

💡 **EXAM TIP —** IB essays often ask "to what extent does [theory] explain [event]?" Always **argue for** one theory but **acknowledge limits** and **bring in a counter-theory**. This shows higher-order thinking and scores evaluation marks.

THE UNITED NATIONS (UN)

Structure

- **General Assembly:** all 193 members; 1 state 1 vote; non-binding resolutions
- **Security Council:** 5 permanent (P5) + 10 rotating; binding Chapter VII resolutions
- **Secretariat:** administrative body; Secretary-General (current: António Guterres)
- **ICJ:** International Court of Justice — legal disputes between states
- **ECOSOC:** economic & social coordination

UN Roles

- Maintain international peace (peacekeeping missions)
- Promote human rights (UDHR, UNHCR)
- Facilitate development (UNDP, SDGs)
- Provide humanitarian aid (WFP, UNICEF)

⚖ EVALUATION — **Strengths:** universal membership, international legitimacy, multilateral forum. **Weaknesses:** P5 veto paralyses UNSC (e.g. Syria, Ukraine); slow; lacks enforcement capacity; depends on member funding.

OTHER KEY INTERNATIONAL ORGANISATIONS

Organisation	Role	Key Critique
NATO	Collective security; Art. 5 mutual defence	US-dominated; Cold War relic?
WTO	Trade rules, dispute resolution	Favours developed nations
IMF	Financial stability, loans	Conditionality = loss of sovereignty
World Bank	Development loans & grants	Structural adjustment critiques
ICC	Prosecute war crimes & genocide	Africa bias; US/China not members
EU	Regional integration; single market	Democratic deficit; Brexit
African Union	African peace & development	Weak enforcement capacity

POWER STRUCTURES DIAGRAM



💡 EXAM TIP — The UN's **P5 veto** is the most-cited structural problem in global governance. Always explain WHY it's a problem (e.g. Russia vetoed 16 resolutions on Syria 2011–2022) and whether reform is realistic.

🔴 THREE GENERATIONS OF RIGHTS

1st Generation — Civil & Political Rights

- Right to life, free speech, fair trial, vote
- Negative rights — state must NOT interfere
- **Framework:** ICCPR (1966)
- **Example:** Freedom of speech (1st Amendment, US)

2nd Generation — Economic, Social, Cultural Rights

- Right to education, healthcare, work, housing
- Positive rights — state must PROVIDE
- **Framework:** ICESCR (1966)
- **Example:** Universal healthcare (UK NHS)

3rd Generation — Collective/Solidarity Rights

- Right to development, clean environment, peace, self-determination
- Group/communal rights
- Most contested — legally unenforceable in most systems
- **Example:** Indigenous land rights, climate justice

⚖️ UNIVERSAL VS CULTURAL RELATIVISM

Universalism

- Rights apply to ALL humans regardless of culture, state, or religion
- UDHR (1948) — universal standard
- **Advocates:** Amnesty International, Western states, UN
- **Argument:** Common humanity transcends culture

VS

Cultural Relativism

- Rights are culturally defined; Western concepts are imposed
- **Advocates:** Some Asian/African states, Malaysia (Asian Values debate)
- **Argument:** Sovereignty; no universal moral framework; colonial legacy of imposed norms

⚖ **EVALUATION — Jack Donnelly:** rights are universal but their implementation may be culturally sensitive. **Amartya Sen:** democracy and human rights are not uniquely "Western." **IB approach:** explore both — don't simply endorse universalism.

📋 KEY LEGAL FRAMEWORKS

Instrument	Year	Key Feature
UDHR	1948	Universal declaration — aspirational, not binding
ICCPR	1966	Civil & political rights — binding treaty
ICESCR	1966	Economic/social rights — binding treaty
ECHR	1950	European system; ECtHR enforces
Rome Statute	1998	Established ICC; war crimes jurisdiction
CRC	1989	Convention on Rights of the Child

💡 **EXAM TIP —** Know the difference between **declarations** (aspirational; not legally binding) and **conventions/treaties** (legally binding upon ratification). Examiners test this distinction frequently.

❌ TYPES OF HUMAN RIGHTS VIOLATIONS

Type	Definition	Example
Genocide	Intent to destroy a national/ethnic/religious group	Rwanda 1994, Darfur, Uyghurs (alleged)
Torture	Cruel, inhuman treatment by state actors	Abu Ghraib (US, Iraq), Guantánamo
Disappearances	State abduction without acknowledgement	Argentina's Dirty War (1976–83)
Mass atrocities	Crimes against humanity at scale	Syria — chemical weapons on civilians
Structural violence	Denial of ESC rights through institutions	Apartheid South Africa, caste system
Discrimination	Denial of rights based on identity	LGBTQ+ criminalisation (80+ states)

🔧 ENFORCEMENT MECHANISMS

International Mechanisms

- **ICC:** prosecutes individuals (not states) for war crimes, crimes against humanity, genocide
- **UN Human Rights Council:** reviews states via Universal Periodic Review (UPR)
- **UN Special Rapporteurs:** investigate specific rights issues
- **Treaty bodies:** monitor compliance with ICCPR, ICESCR, etc.

Regional Mechanisms

- **European Court of Human Rights (ECtHR):** most effective regional body
- **Inter-American Court of Human Rights**
- **African Court on Human and Peoples' Rights**

🌍 RESPONSIBILITY TO PROTECT (R2P)

Three Pillars (UN World Summit 2005)

- **Pillar 1:** State has primary responsibility to protect its own citizens
- **Pillar 2:** International community assists states to fulfil R2P
- **Pillar 3:** If state fails, international community may intervene (UNSC authorisation required)

Arguments FOR R2P

- Prevents mass atrocities
- Rwanda genocide — failure to act
- Upholds human rights over sovereignty

Arguments AGAINST R2P

- Sovereignty violation — who decides?
- Libya 2011 — regime change, not protection
- Selective application (politics > principle)
- Russia used R2P to justify Ukraine 2014

⚖ **EVALUATION —** R2P represents a shift from "sovereignty as right" to "sovereignty as responsibility." However, its application has been inconsistent and politicised — P5 veto often blocks action (Syria). It remains contested between sovereignty norms and humanitarian obligations.

⚠ **COMMON MISTAKE —** Don't confuse **R2P** with **humanitarian intervention**. R2P is a broader political commitment adopted in 2005; humanitarian intervention (e.g. Kosovo 1999) was unauthorised by UNSC and therefore controversial under international law.

CASE STUDY

ROHINGYA CRISIS — MYANMAR/BANGLADESH

- **Context:** Buddhist-majority Myanmar; Rohingya = Muslim minority, stateless since 1982 Citizenship Law
- **2017:** Military crackdown ("clearance operations") — mass killings, rape, burning of villages
- **750,000+** fled to Bangladesh (Cox's Bazar refugee camp — world's largest)
- **ICJ case:** Gambia v. Myanmar — genocide proceedings ongoing
- **UNHCR involvement:** limited returns due to safety concerns

⚖ **EVALUATION —** Illustrates: failure of R2P (UNSC paralysis), statelessness as root cause, limits of international justice (ICJ slow), role of NGOs in humanitarian response.

CASE STUDY

UYGHUR INTERNMENT — CHINA (XINJIANG)

- **Context:** Muslim Turkic minority in northwest China
- **Evidence:** 1 million+ in "re-education camps" (leaked Xinjiang Police Files, 2022)
- **China's position:** voluntary vocational training; counter-terrorism
- **UN:** OHCHR 2022 report — "serious human rights violations, possible crimes against humanity"
- **Response:** US Uyghur Forced Labor Prevention Act; diplomatic boycott of 2022 Beijing Olympics

⚖ **EVALUATION —** Illustrates: tension between sovereignty and human rights, limits of enforcement against P5 members, economic interests undermining human rights responses, contested definitions (cultural relativism).

CASE STUDY

SOUTH AFRICA — APARTHEID TO DEMOCRACY

- **Context:** Racial segregation 1948–1994 — denial of civil, political, economic rights to Black South Africans
- **International response:** UN sanctions, divestment campaigns, global boycotts
- **Constructivist lens:** norm change driven by civil society; ANC advocacy
- **1994:** Democratic elections — Mandela elected President
- **TRC:** Truth and Reconciliation Commission — restorative justice model

⚖ **EVALUATION —** Illustrates: soft power of norm cascades, effectiveness of sanctions, constructivist theory in practice, transitional justice mechanisms.

CASE STUDY

LGBTQ+ RIGHTS AS HUMAN RIGHTS

- 80+ countries still criminalise same-sex relationships
- **Landmark:** Lawrence v. Texas (US, 2003); Obergefell v. Hodges (US, 2015)
- **UN:** Human Rights Council Resolution 17/19 (2011) — first on sexual orientation
- **Debate:** universalism vs cultural/religious relativism
- **Example:** Uganda's Anti-Homosexuality Act 2023 — international condemnation; World Bank withdrew loans

💡 **EXAM TIP —** LGBTQ+ rights cases are excellent for illustrating the **universalism vs relativism debate** — use when asked about cultural relativism or enforcement challenges.

DEVELOPMENT INDICATORS

Indicator	Measures	Critique
GDP/GNI per capita	Average income/economic output	Ignores distribution; hides inequality
HDI	Income + education + life expectancy	Still misses inequality; no sustainability
IHDI	HDI adjusted for inequality	More nuanced; harder to compare
Gini coefficient	Income inequality within country	Abstract; doesn't capture absolute poverty
MPI	Multi-dimensional poverty (health, education, living standards)	Most holistic; Oxford Poverty & Human Dev. Initiative
Gender Inequality Index	Reproductive health, empowerment, labour	Cross-cultural comparison difficult

💡 **EXAM TIP —** Always critically evaluate development indicators — GDP is most cited but most limited. For high marks, use **HDI + Gini** together to show a nuanced picture. Mention that Sen's **Capability Approach** challenges purely economic measures.

GLOBAL INEQUALITY

- Top 10% own ~76% of global wealth (Oxfam 2023)
- **Within-country inequality** rising faster than between-country
- Structural causes: colonial legacy, extractive institutions, debt traps
- SDG 10: Reduce inequality within and between countries

DEVELOPMENT THEORIES

Modernisation Theory (Rostow, 1960)

- All societies follow 5 linear stages: Traditional → Take-off → Mass Consumption
- Development requires capital investment, Western institutions, technology transfer
- **Critique:** Eurocentric; ignores colonial exploitation; assumes Western model is ideal

Dependency Theory (Frank, 1966)

- "Development of underdevelopment" — Global South underdeveloped BY the Global North
- Core-periphery model: extractive relationships perpetuate poverty
- **Critique:** Overly structural; ignores internal governance; some "periphery" nations developed (East Asia)

Capability Approach (Amartya Sen)

- Development = expanding real human freedoms and capabilities
- GDP is not enough — focus on what people can actually DO and BE
- Influenced HDI and the Sustainable Development Goals

⚖ **EVALUATION —** These three theories represent a **spectrum**: Modernisation (liberal economic), Dependency (structuralist/Marxist), Capability (human-centred). Use all three to evaluate development strategies.

💰 AID

Types of Aid

- **Bilateral:** state to state (e.g. USAID)
- **Multilateral:** via IGOs (World Bank, UNDP)
- **Humanitarian:** emergency relief (MSF, WFP)
- **Tied aid:** conditions benefiting donor
- **Budget support:** directly to government

For Aid

- Saves lives in emergencies
- Builds human capital
- Jeffrey Sachs: aid can end poverty (Big Push)

Against Aid

- Dambisa Moyo: "Dead Aid" — aid creates dependency, undermines governance
- Corruption & misuse
- Tied aid benefits donors

CASE

Millennium Village Project (Sachs, 2006–15): concentrated aid in Sub-Saharan Africa — mixed results; praised for health gains, criticised for sustainability after funding ended.

🔄 TRADE

Trade as Development

- Comparative advantage (Ricardo) — specialise in efficient goods
- WTO rules reduce barriers; FTAs increase market access
- Export-led growth (East Asian Tigers: South Korea, Taiwan)

For Trade

- China lifted 800 million from poverty through export manufacturing
- Technology transfer, FDI
- Reduces aid dependency

Against Trade

- Unfair terms: Global South exports raw materials, buys manufactured goods
- Agricultural subsidies (EU/US) hurt Global South farmers
- Race to bottom on labour rights

CASE

China's BRI: infrastructure investment in 150+ countries — promotes development but critics cite "debt-trap diplomacy" (Sri Lanka's Hambantota Port, 2017).

♻️ SUSTAINABLE DEVELOPMENT

SDGs (2015–2030)

- 17 goals, 169 targets — successor to MDGs
- No poverty, zero hunger, good health, quality education, gender equality, clean energy, climate action...
- **Key tension:** economic growth (SDG 8) vs. environment (SDG 13)

Sustainable Development Triangle



SDG Progress

- Extreme poverty halved vs 1990
- Child mortality down 60%

SDG Challenges

- COVID-19 reversed gains
- Climate change threatens all goals
- Financing gap: $2.5tn/year

💡 **EXAM TIP —** For development essay questions, structure your argument using the **Aid vs Trade vs Governance** framework. Always evaluate using **Sachs vs Moyo** (aid debate) and **modernisation vs dependency** (trade debate).

CASE STUDY

CHINA — RAPID DEVELOPMENT

- 800 million lifted from poverty (1980–2015) — largest poverty reduction in history
- State-directed capitalism + export manufacturing + FDI
- **Key policies:** SEZs (Shenzhen), BRI, "Made in China 2025"
- **HDI:** rose from Low to High Human Development in 30 years
- **Contradictions:** rising inequality (Gini ~0.38), environmental degradation, political repression

⚖ **EVALUATION —** China's development challenges modernisation theory (state-led, not pure market) AND dependency theory (engaged with global trade system successfully). Supports Deng's pragmatism: "it doesn't matter if the cat is black or white."

CASE STUDY

HIPC INITIATIVE — DEBT RELIEF

- Heavily Indebted Poor Countries initiative (IMF/World Bank, 1996)
- Cancelled billions in debt for 36 countries (mostly Sub-Saharan Africa)
- **Conditions:** structural adjustment — privatisation, trade liberalisation, fiscal austerity
- **Outcome:** freed up government spending for health & education (Zambia, Tanzania)
- **Critique:** conditionality reduced state sovereignty; neoliberal model imposed

CASE STUDY

BANGLADESH — MICRO-FINANCE & NGOS

- Grameen Bank (Muhammad Yunus, 1983) — micro-credit to rural poor, especially women
- 9 million+ borrowers; 97% women; 95% repayment rate
- **Impact:** poverty reduction, female empowerment, local enterprise
- **BRAC:** world's largest NGO — healthcare, education, livelihood programs
- Bangladesh now lower-middle income — garment sector central
- **Tension:** Rana Plaza collapse 2013 — labour rights vs economic development

⚖ **EVALUATION —** Illustrates: role of NGOs, gendered development, micro-finance as bottom-up alternative to top-down aid, tensions between economic development and workers' rights.

EVALUATION: WHAT WORKS FOR DEVELOPMENT?

Approach	Strength	Weakness
Foreign Aid	Emergency relief, builds capacity	Dependency, corruption risk
FDI/Trade	Growth, jobs, technology	Exploitation, inequality
Microfinance	Empowers local actors, women	High interest rates, limited scale
Debt relief	Frees government resources	Conditionality, repeated cycles
Governance reform	Addresses root causes	Slow, contested, sovereignty
Technology/Innovation	Leapfrogging (e.g. mobile banking, M-Pesa Kenya)	Digital divide, infrastructure gap

💡 **EXAM TIP —** The IB loves the question: "Is trade more effective than aid for development?" Always distinguish between **types** of each, use **case studies** (China vs Sub-Saharan Africa), and evaluate using development theories.

🔴 TYPES OF CONFLICT

Type	Features	Example
Interstate War	Between sovereign states; formal declaration; declining in frequency post-1945	Gulf War 1990–91; Russia–Ukraine 2022
Civil War / Intrastate	Within a state; between government & armed groups; most common post-Cold War	Syrian Civil War, Yemen, South Sudan
Proxy War	External powers support opposing sides without direct involvement	Yemen (Saudi vs Iran), Angola (Cold War)
Asymmetric War	Conventional state vs non-state/insurgent actor; different capabilities	US in Afghanistan, Iraq
Hybrid War	Combines conventional, irregular, cyber, disinformation	Russia in Ukraine (2014 onwards)
New Wars	Post-Cold War; economic motives, identity, non-state actors (Mary Kaldor)	DRC, Somalia, Libya

🌿 JOHAN GALTUNG'S PEACE FRAMEWORK

Negative Peace

- Absence of direct violence
- Ceasefires, peace agreements
- Short-term, fragile
- **Example:** Armistice, UN peacekeeping

Positive Peace

- Absence of structural & cultural violence
- Just institutions, equality, development
- Long-term, sustainable
- **Example:** post-apartheid South Africa's TRC

🔍 CAUSES OF CONFLICT

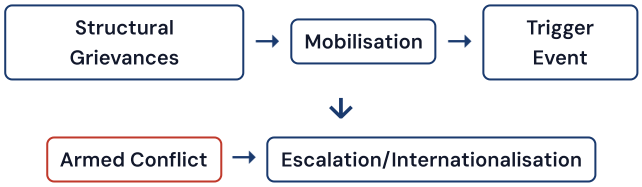
Structural Causes (Background)

- Poverty & inequality — relative deprivation theory (Gurr)
- Weak/failed states — cannot maintain monopoly on violence
- Colonial borders — arbitrary lines created ethnic tensions (Africa)
- Natural resources — "resource curse" (oil, diamonds, minerals)
- Historical grievances — unresolved injustices

Proximate Causes (Immediate Triggers)

- Political repression, election fraud
- Economic crisis, food shortage
- Ethnic/religious discrimination
- External interference (arms supply)

Conflict Escalation Flowchart



⚖ **EVALUATION —** Paul Collier's **"greed vs grievance"** debate: conflicts driven by economic motives (looting, resource control) rather than genuine political grievances. Evidence: DRC, Sierra Leone. Counter: grievances are real but manipulated by elites.

APPROACHES TO PEACE

Approach	Focus	Tools	Example
Peacekeeping	Monitor ceasefires; protect civilians	UN blue helmets; Chapter VI	MINUSMA (Mali), MONUSCO (DRC)
Peace enforcement	Impose peace by force	Chapter VII; use of force	INTERFET (East Timor 1999), Libya 2011
Peacemaking	Negotiate agreement	Mediation, diplomacy	Oslo Accords, Good Friday Agreement
Peacebuilding	Address root causes post-conflict	Reconstruction, DDR, governance	Post-war Bosnia, Rwanda
Preventive diplomacy	Prevent conflict before outbreak	Early warning, sanctions	UN preventive deployment (Macedonia 1992)

ROLE OF INTERNATIONAL ORGANISATIONS

United Nations

- **Chapter VI:** pacific settlement — negotiation, mediation, arbitration
- **Chapter VII:** enforcement action — sanctions, military force
- UN Peacebuilding Commission (2005) — post-conflict recovery
- **Weakness:** UNSC veto frequently paralyses action

Regional Organisations

- **NATO:** collective defence; Kosovo (1999), Afghanistan (2001–21)
- **African Union:** AMISOM (Somalia), principle of "African solutions for African problems"
- **ECOWAS:** West Africa peacekeeping (Liberia, Sierra Leone)
- **EU:** EUFOR missions; civilian & military crisis management

TRANSITIONAL JUSTICE

Mechanisms

- **Prosecution:** ICC, ICTY, ICTR — individual criminal accountability
- **TRCs:** Truth & Reconciliation Commissions — South Africa, Colombia
- **Reparations:** financial or symbolic compensation
- **Institutional reform:** security sector reform (SSR), constitution
- **Memory:** memorials, archives, education

For Prosecution (ICC)

- Ends impunity culture
- Deters future atrocities
- Victim recognition

Against / Limits

- May prolong conflict (Sudan: Al-Bashir ICC warrant)
- "Africa bias" critique
- US, Russia, China not members
- Enforcement depends on states

⚖ **EVALUATION — Justice vs Peace trade-off:** Prosecuting leaders may end peace negotiations (Sudan). Amnesty enables peace but denies justice (Mozambique). Hybrid models (Colombia's Special Jurisdiction for Peace) attempt balance — reduced sentences for truth-telling.

💡 **EXAM TIP —** Use DDR (Disarmament, Demobilisation, Rehabilitation) as a specific peacebuilding tool — and evaluate its success. Example: failed DDR in Libya → renewed civil war. Successful DDR in Sierra Leone (UNAMSIL).

CASE STUDY

SYRIAN CIVIL WAR (2011–PRESENT)

- **Origins:** Arab Spring protests → Assad regime crackdown → armed insurgency
- **Actors:** Assad government (backed by Russia, Iran), opposition factions, ISIS, Kurdish SDF, Turkey
- **Scale:** 500,000+ dead, 12 million displaced (half Syria's pre-war population)
- **UN failure:** Russia & China vetoed 16 UNSC resolutions 2011–2022
- **Chemical weapons:** Ghouta attack 2013 — Obama's "red line" → inaction
- **OPCW involvement:** Chemical weapons dismantled (2013) but continued use

⚖ **EVALUATION —** Syria is the definitive case for: UNSC paralysis (P5 veto), failure of R2P, proxy war dynamics, humanitarian law violations, refugee crisis, and the limits of international law.

CASE STUDY

KOSOVO & HUMANITARIAN INTERVENTION (1999)

- NATO bombing of Yugoslavia without UNSC authorisation
- Justified by: ethnic cleansing of Albanian Kosovars by Serbian forces
- "Illegal but legitimate" — Independent International Commission on Kosovo
- Led to Kosovo's independence (2008) — recognised by 100+ states, not Russia/China
- Precedent for R2P debate and sovereignty vs humanitarian intervention

⚖ **EVALUATION —** Kosovo shows the tension between legality (UN Charter Art. 2.4) and legitimacy (preventing atrocities). Realists: illegal; Liberals: justified; Constructivists: shifted humanitarian intervention norm.

CASE STUDY

RWANDA GENOCIDE (1994)

- **800,000+** Tutsi and moderate Hutu killed in 100 days (April–July 1994)
- **International failure:** UNAMIR commander Roméo Dallaire warned UN — no reinforcements sent
- US: Clinton admin avoided word "genocide" to prevent obligation to act
- France complicit (supported Hutu government)
- **Aftermath:** ICTR established; Gacaca community courts; reconciliation
- Rwanda became key justification for R2P doctrine (2005)

⚖ **EVALUATION —** Rwanda is the paradigm case of **international failure** and the motivation for R2P. Use with Bosnia (Srebrenica, 1995) as parallel failure. Contrast with Kosovo where intervention occurred.

CASE STUDY

COLOMBIA PEACE PROCESS (2016)

- FARC–government peace agreement after 52 years of civil war
- **Key features:** land reform, political participation, Special Jurisdiction for Peace (transitional justice)
- Nobel Peace Prize 2016 (President Santos)
- **Challenges:** referendum rejected agreement initially; implementation slow; FARC dissidents
- Illustrates: DDR challenges, justice-peace trade-off, international mediation (Cuba, Norway)

💡 **EXAM TIP —** For Peace & Conflict essays: always address **both causes AND responses**. Use the Galtung framework (negative/positive peace) to evaluate whether a resolution is truly sustainable.

HL ONLY HL students complete a 2,000-word Global Political Challenge (GPC) essay worth 35% of the final mark. Choose one GPC and write an extended argument with specific examples, multiple perspectives, and deep evaluation.

🌡️ CLIMATE CHANGE AS GLOBAL POLITICAL CHALLENGE

Political Dimensions

- Collective action problem — states prioritise national interest over global commons
- North-South tension: **historical responsibility** vs **current emissions**
- Climate justice — vulnerable states bear least responsibility, most harm
- UNFCCC & Paris Agreement (2015) — NDCs; non-binding
- 1.5°C vs 2°C target; current trajectories = 2.7–3°C

Global Cooperation Progress

- 193 parties to Paris Agreement
- Renewable energy growth exponential
- Climate finance ($100bn/yr pledged)

Obstacles

- US withdrew under Trump (2017); rejoined Biden (2021)
- Major emitters underpromise
- Loss and Damage fund (COP27) — underfunded

⚖ **EVALUATION —** Climate change tests all IR theories: Realists point to free-rider problems; Liberals see progress through UNFCCC; Constructivists note shifting norms (youth movement, Greta Thunberg, IPCC moral authority).

🦠 GLOBAL HEALTH AS POLITICAL CHALLENGE

COVID-19 Pandemic

- 7 million+ deaths; global GDP fell 3.1% (2020)
- **WHO:** coordinating body — criticised for slow response, deference to China
- **Vaccine nationalism:** rich countries hoarded vaccines; COVAX underfunded
- TRIPS waiver debate — intellectual property vs access
- Reversed development gains: SDG setback of 10–15 years

⚖ **EVALUATION —** COVID-19 exposed: global governance gaps (WHO authority), inequality between states (vaccine access), tension between open information sharing and economic competition, failure of multilateral institutions under pressure.

📱 TECHNOLOGY & CYBER AS POLITICAL CHALLENGE

- Cyber warfare — Stuxnet (US/Israel vs Iran nuclear programme)
- Disinformation — election interference (Russia 2016 US election)
- Surveillance capitalism — data as geopolitical resource
- AI governance — no binding international treaty
- Digital divide — access inequality as development issue
- Tech sovereignty — Huawei controversy; 5G security debates

💡 **EXAM TIP —** For HL, demonstrate **independent thinking** in your GPC essay. Use at least 3 perspectives (e.g. Realist state competition, Liberal institutional cooperation, Constructivist norm emergence) and anchor to specific, named case studies.

HL ONLY Political Engagement Activity (PEA): HL students participate in a genuine political activity and submit a reflective journal (1,500–2,000 words). It must be a real engagement (e.g. lobbying, protest, campaign, policy research).

🌐 MIGRATION & REFUGEES AS GPC

- 108 million+ forcibly displaced globally (UNHCR 2023) — record high
- **Refugees** (cross border, persecution-based) vs **IDPs** (within borders)
- 1951 Refugee Convention: non-refoulement principle
- Global Compact for Refugees (2018) — non-binding; burden-sharing
- **Key tensions:** sovereignty vs protection, security concerns, cultural integration
- **EU:** Dublin Regulation disputes; Hungarian/Polish pushbacks

⚖ **EVALUATION —** Realists: migration threatens sovereignty, national security; Liberals: international law obligations (Refugee Convention); Constructivists: "refugee" identity socially constructed — who counts as a refugee shapes policy.

🔱 RISE OF CHINA & CHANGING WORLD ORDER

- GDP PPP: China overtook US c. 2015 (IMF)
- BRI: 150+ countries; infrastructure + political influence
- South China Sea: territorial claims, UNCLOS violations (2016 PCA ruling)
- "Thucydides Trap" — Allison: rising vs ruling power = conflict risk
- Taiwan: cross-strait tensions; US strategic ambiguity policy
- BRICS expansion (2024): Saudi Arabia, UAE, Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran joined

⚖ **EVALUATION —** Is the world becoming bipolar (US vs China) or multipolar? Realists: security competition inevitable; Liberals: interdependence (US–China trade $700bn) deters conflict; Constructivists: identity gap is the real danger.

🔗 HL: ADVANCED EVALUATION FRAMEWORKS

How to Write a Top HL Essay

- **Thesis:** clear, contestable argument in opening paragraph
- **Structure:** 4–5 paragraphs — each with claim, evidence, analysis, counter-argument
- **Theory integration:** apply 2–3 IR theories explicitly
- **Case studies:** minimum 3 specific, named examples
- **Evaluation:** acknowledge limitations of your own argument
- **Conclusion:** nuanced — avoid simplistic "yes/no" answers

HL GPC Essay Planning Template

Section	Content	Words
Introduction	Context, thesis, scope	~200
Paragraph 1	Main argument + case study	~350
Paragraph 2	Supporting argument + IR theory	~350
Paragraph 3	Counter-argument + evaluation	~350
Paragraph 4	Alternative perspective	~300
Conclusion	Synthesis + nuanced judgement	~200
Total		**~1,750–2,000**

💡 **EXAM TIP —** For the GPC essay, the IB rewards **conceptual sophistication**. Use terms like "structural violence," "hegemonic stability," "norm cascade," "epistemic community," and "securitisation" — but only when used accurately.

⚠ COMMON MISTAKE — **1. Description instead of analysis**

Many students describe what happened (e.g. "Syria had a civil war") without explaining WHY and evaluating implications. Analysis = causes + consequences + multiple perspectives.

⚠ COMMON MISTAKE — **2. Ignoring counter-arguments**

Top-scoring essays always address **at least one counter-argument**. A one-sided essay misses evaluation marks entirely. Use "however," "on the other hand," "critics argue."

⚠ COMMON MISTAKE — **3. Vague case studies**

"A country in Africa" or "a war in the Middle East" scores nothing. Use SPECIFIC names: Ghouta attack, Hambantota Port, Grameen Bank, Oslo Accords. Be precise with dates.

⚠ COMMON MISTAKE — **4. Confusing sovereignty and power**

Sovereignty = legal right to rule. Power = capacity to act. A state can be sovereign but weak (Somalia). Always distinguish these clearly.

⚠ COMMON MISTAKE — **5. Treating the UN as all-powerful**

The UN is only as powerful as its member states allow. Always acknowledge the P5 veto, funding dependence, and implementation challenges.

⚠ COMMON MISTAKE — **6. Ignoring the difference between declarations and treaties**

UDHR (1948) = aspirational declaration; NOT legally binding. ICCPR/ICESCR = binding treaties. This distinction is frequently tested.

⚠ COMMON MISTAKE — **7. Oversimplifying IR theories**

Realism ≠ "war is inevitable." Liberalism ≠ "peace through trade always works." Apply theories critically — acknowledge internal debates (neorealism vs classical realism).

⚠ COMMON MISTAKE — **8. Misusing R2P**

R2P is NOT a legal right to intervene — it requires UNSC authorisation. NATO Kosovo (1999) was NOT authorised under R2P (it predates R2P). Libya 2011 WAS R2P-authorised but controversially applied.

⚠ COMMON MISTAKE — **9. Confusing HDI and GDP**

GDP measures only economic output. HDI includes health and education. Gulf states like Qatar have very high GDP but their HDI tells a more nuanced story. Always use HDI for development arguments.

⚠ COMMON MISTAKE — **10. Forgetting non-state actors**

Questions about "global actors" or "power" should ALWAYS include NGOs, TNCs, and armed non-state actors — not just states. Missing these limits your marks significantly.

⚠ COMMON MISTAKE — **11. Writing "aid is good/bad" without nuance**

The Sachs vs Moyo debate shows aid is neither uniformly good nor bad — type, context, and governance matter. Emergency humanitarian aid ≠ long-term structural aid.

⚠ COMMON MISTAKE — **12. Using only Western sources and perspectives**

IB expects global perspectives. Cite African Union positions, Chinese foreign policy logic, Latin American dependency theorists (Frank), and non-Western case studies.

⚠ COMMON MISTAKE — **13. Answering a different question**

Read the command term CAREFULLY. "Discuss" ≠ "Evaluate" ≠ "Examine." Misidentifying the command term is the single most common reason for losing marks.

⚠ COMMON MISTAKE — **14. Weak conclusions**

Don't just summarise — make a **final, nuanced judgement**. "Overall, while X is significant, Y is more important because..." Avoid: "In conclusion, there are many perspectives."

📋 IB COMMAND TERMS — GLOBAL POLITICS

Term	What It Means	What Examiners Want
Discuss	Consider multiple perspectives on an issue	Balanced argument: for & against; perspectives; no strong personal opinion needed
Evaluate	Make a judgement based on evidence	Assess strengths AND weaknesses; end with reasoned conclusion
Examine	Consider carefully the nature or extent	Detailed analysis; show depth of understanding
Analyse	Break down in detail; identify components	Causes, effects, significance; show relationships
Compare and contrast	Identify similarities and differences	Must do BOTH; structured comparison; avoid treating separately
To what extent	Assess degree; make a judgement on the scale	Argue "to a large/limited extent" — defend with evidence; acknowledge contrary evidence
Justify	Give valid reasons for a conclusion	Argue why; provide strong evidence; some counter-argument

✍️ PAPER 1 (STRUCTURED QUESTIONS) STRATEGY

- **Part a) (short answer, 2–4 marks):** define concept + 1 example. Be precise. 2–3 sentences max.
- **Part b) (medium, 8 marks):** structured paragraph — define, explain, apply case study. 1–2 perspectives.
- **Part c) (extended, 14 marks):** full mini-essay — thesis, 3 paragraphs, counter-argument, conclusion. ~400 words.

✍️ PAPER 2 (EXTENDED ESSAY) STRUCTURE

Recommended Structure (1,000–1,200 words)

- **Introduction (100–120 words):**
  — Hook / global context statement
  — Define key terms
  — Clear thesis sentence
- **Body Para 1 (250 words):**
  — Topic sentence (main argument)
  — Evidence / case study (specific, named)
  — IR theory lens
  — Analysis of significance
- **Body Para 2 (250 words):**
  — Supporting argument
  — Second case study
  — Link to thesis
- **Counterargument Para (200 words):**
  — Acknowledge opposing perspective
  — Refute with evidence
  — Strengthen your thesis
- **Conclusion (100–150 words):**
  — Restate thesis (differently)
  — Synthesise main points
  — Final nuanced judgement
  — Wider implication

💡 **EXAM TIP — Time management:** Paper 2 = 90 minutes total for 2 essays. Spend 5 min planning each. Write for 35–38 min each. Leave 5 min to proofread. Never skip planning — even 3 bullet points will save 15 minutes of rambling.

Evaluation Sentence Starters

- "However, critics argue that..."
- "While this is compelling, from a realist perspective..."
- "This case illustrates both the potential and limitations of..."
- "Ultimately, the extent to which X depends on..."
- "A more nuanced view suggests..."

🔵 SECTION 1 — POWER & IR

- Hard / soft / smart power
- Westphalian sovereignty (1648)
- State + non-state actors (IGOs, NGOs, TNCs)
- Realism: anarchy, self-help, balance of power
- Liberalism: interdependence, institutions, democratic peace
- Constructivism: norms, identity, social construction
- UN structure: UNGA, UNSC, P5 veto, ICJ
- Unipolar → Bipolar → Multipolar

🔴 SECTION 2 — HUMAN RIGHTS

- 3 generations: civil/political → ESC → collective
- Universalism vs cultural relativism
- UDHR (1948), ICCPR, ICESCR
- Declaration ≠ Treaty (binding distinction)
- ICC vs ICJ — individual vs state jurisdiction
- R2P: 3 pillars (2005); Libya; Syria veto
- ECtHR — most effective enforcement mechanism
- Cases: Rohingya, Uyghur, Apartheid, Rwanda

🟡 SECTION 3 — DEVELOPMENT

- GDP vs HDI vs MPI — limits of each
- Modernisation (Rostow) vs Dependency (Frank)
- Capability Approach (Sen)
- Aid: Sachs (pro) vs Moyo (against)
- Trade: comparative advantage; BRI
- SDGs: 17 goals, 2015–2030
- Cases: China, Bangladesh, HIPC
- Resource curse; structural adjustment

🟢 SECTION 4 — PEACE & CONFLICT

- Interstate vs civil vs proxy vs hybrid war
- Galtung: negative peace vs positive peace
- Causes: structural (inequality, resources) + proximate (trigger)
- Peacekeeping vs peacebuilding vs peacemaking
- UN Chapter VI (pacific) vs VII (enforcement)
- DDR — disarmament, demobilisation, rehabilitation
- TRC — restorative justice (South Africa)
- Cases: Syria, Rwanda, Kosovo, Colombia

📝 NIGHT-BEFORE CHECKLIST

- [ ] Know 2+ case studies per topic (named, dated, specific)
- [ ] Can explain all 3 IR theories with examples
- [ ] Know the difference: declaration vs treaty
- [ ] Can define: sovereignty, legitimacy, hard/soft power, R2P
- [ ] Know key development indicators (HDI, GDP, Gini, MPI)
- [ ] Can name the P5 Security Council members
- [ ] Know Galtung's positive vs negative peace
- [ ] Command terms: discuss, evaluate, to what extent
- [ ] Have a 5-minute essay plan structure ready
- [ ] Know at least one non-Western theorist per topic
- [ ] HL: Can outline GPC essay argument with 3 case studies
- [ ] Read over Common Mistakes list (page 18)

Good luck — you've got this.

Remember: IB Global Politics rewards structured thinking, real examples, and genuine evaluation. Show the examiner that you understand complexity.